

# Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 34

**Time allowed:** 1 hour 50 minutes

**Total marks for Sections B and C:** 45

## Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [ ] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

## Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

**Text 3:** A street-sweeper, working a quiet pre-dawn shift, hears a thin mewling from a storm drain and pulls a small drenched kitten to safety.

1

At twenty past four in the morning, the city belonged almost entirely to Mr Tan. The traffic lights, observed by no one in particular, blinked their patient green and red through a faint mist. Shutters were down. The bakeries had not yet woken. Even the stray dogs that usually patrolled the back lane behind the wet market were curled, somewhere, in dreaming heaps. Mr Tan, sixty-three years old and as solitary as a lamp post, pushed his broad rattan broom along the gutter with the steady, unhurried rhythm of a man who had been sweeping these streets for nineteen years and expected to sweep them for nineteen more.

2

He liked this hour. He liked the way the streetlights made small, kindly pools on the pavement, and the way the air, for once, smelled of nothing in particular. The day shift, when it came, would bring exhaust fumes and the sharp commercial smells of food courts opening up; but at twenty past four, the city smelled almost clean. Mr Tan was not a sentimental man — he would have laughed, gruffly, at the suggestion — but in a quiet way he treasured these dawn rounds. They asked nothing of him beyond what he already gave.

3

He had reached the corner of Selegie Road, and was bending to lift a damp clump of newspaper from the storm drain, when he heard it. A thin, half-broken sound, barely above a breath. He paused, his old back creaking, and listened. The sound came again — not the rusty squeak of a hinge, not the chirp of an early bird, but something softer and more insistent. A mewling. He set down the broom carefully, the way one sets down a thing one suddenly does not wish to drop, and crouched at the lip of the drain.

4

The drain was dark, of course, and the night's rain had filled it to the ankle. He fished out the small

torch he kept clipped to his belt and shone it down. At first he saw only wet leaves, a crushed cup, and the slow oil-shine of standing water. Then, near the far wall, something pale moved. Two small eyes, no larger than coffee beans, caught the torchlight and held it, frightened and unblinking. A kitten — no more than a few weeks old, by the look of it — was crouched on a thin ledge above the water, soaked through and shivering so hard that its whole body shuddered with each breath.

5

Mr Tan, who had not in his life owned a cat, surprised himself by speaking to it. “All right, all right,” he murmured, as if calming a frightened child. “Don’t move. Don’t be afraid.” He lowered himself onto his knees on the wet kerb, ignoring the cold that bit through his trousers, and reached his arm slowly down. The kitten flinched, scrambled half an inch backwards, and almost fell. Mr Tan stopped. He waited. He waited so long that his shoulder began to ache. Then, very gently, he tried again, and this time the small wet creature did not move. His fingers closed, with extraordinary care, around a body no bigger than a bread roll.

6

He brought it up into the lamplight. It was a mottled grey, with one white sock on its hind leg, and it weighed less than a packet of dried noodles. It was shaking so violently that Mr Tan, without thinking, unzipped his bright orange uniform jacket and tucked the kitten against the warmth of his chest, the way he had once seen a young mother on the bus tuck a baby. The kitten gave a single, surprised mewl, and then was silent. Beneath his jacket, he could feel its small frantic heartbeat slowing, slowing, against his own.

7

He stood for a long moment on the empty street. There was, he knew, a shelter on the other side of town that opened at eight. There were also several rules in the municipal handbook about animals on shift. He thought of these things, briefly, the way a man thinks of weather he intends to ignore. Then he picked up his broom with his free hand, slid it onto its rack on the cart, and turned for home. His flat was twenty minutes’ walk away. He had a half-tin of sardines in the cupboard. He had, he supposed, a saucer somewhere.

8

For nineteen years Mr Tan had walked home alone at the end of his shift, and for nineteen years he had not minded. He minded, now, the thought of putting this small wet thing down. He could feel it breathing under his jacket, a tiny, regular movement against his ribs, as though something inside him that he had forgotten about had remembered, all at once, how to be tender. The city was beginning, very faintly, to wake. Mr Tan, sixty-three years old and no longer quite as solitary as a lamp post, walked carefully home through the lifting dark.

### From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says that “the city belonged almost entirely to Mr Tan.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase tells us about the streets at this hour. [2]

2. Mr Tan is described as “as solitary as a lamp post.” What does this comparison suggest about him? [2]

### From Paragraph 2

3. Give **two** details from Paragraph 2 that show Mr Tan finds peace in working at this hour. [2]

### From Paragraph 3

4. The narrator says Mr Tan “set down the broom carefully, the way one sets down a thing one suddenly does not wish to drop.” What does this action suggest about his state of mind at this moment? [2]

**From Paragraph 4**

5. The kitten’s eyes are described as “no larger than coffee beans.”

(a) What does this comparison suggest about the size of the kitten? [1]

(b) Why might the writer have chosen an everyday object for this comparison, rather than something more dramatic? [1]

**From Paragraph 5**

6. The narrator says Mr Tan spoke to the kitten “as if calming a frightened child.” Explain how the language used in Paragraph 5 makes Mr Tan’s behaviour seem unusually tender. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 5. [3]

**From Paragraph 6**

7. The narrator says that the kitten’s heartbeat slowed “against his own.” Explain what this detail suggests about the moment between man and kitten. [2]

8. The kitten is said to weigh “less than a packet of dried noodles.” What does this comparison suggest about Mr Tan’s feelings towards the kitten? [1]

**From Paragraph 7**

9. Give **one** piece of evidence from Paragraph 7 that shows Mr Tan has decided, almost without deliberation, to keep the kitten. [1]

**From Paragraph 8**

10. The narrator says that “something inside him that he had forgotten about had remembered, all at once, how to be tender.” What does this tell us about how Mr Tan has changed in this single morning? [2]

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

**Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]**

**Text 4: A feature article on the science of why we cry — what tears are made of, what they may signal, and what they do for us.**

**1**

Of all the strange things our bodies do, crying is perhaps the most peculiar. We weep when we are sad, but also when we are overjoyed; we weep at funerals, but also at weddings, at violin concertos, at the closing pages of novels. No other species, as far as we can tell, produces emotional tears in this way. Dogs whimper, elephants mourn, monkeys grieve, but the slow leaking of salt water down the cheek when a loved one walks back through the door appears to be ours alone. The science of crying is, accordingly, both unfinished and oddly fascinating.

**2**

Tears, biologists tell us, come in three distinct kinds. **Basal** tears are the ones we never notice: a constant, microscopically thin film that bathes the eye, keeps the cornea smooth, and washes away dust. **Reflex** tears are the ones produced when the eye is irritated — by chopped onions, by smoke, by a stray eyelash — and serve to flush the irritant away. **Emotional** tears, finally, are the ones that interest psychologists most. They are produced not in response to the eye itself but in response to feeling, and their chemistry, curiously, is not the same as the other two.

**3**

Analyses of emotional tears, beginning with the work of the American biochemist William Frey in the 1980s, have found that they contain noticeably higher concentrations of certain proteins and stress-related hormones than basal or reflex tears do. This has led some researchers to suggest that emotional crying serves a **chemical** function — a way of physically excreting hormones that build up under stress. Other scientists are more cautious, pointing out that the quantities involved are small and that no one has yet demonstrated, in a controlled trial, that a good cry leaves the body chemically calmer. The chemistry, in short, is suggestive but not yet settled.

**4**

What seems clearer is that emotional tears are a kind of social signal. Human beings have unusually visible eyes — the white sclera of our eyes is far larger and more exposed than that of any other primate — and a tear running down the cheek of another person is, for most of us, very hard to ignore. Studies in which volunteers are shown the same face with and without digitally added tears find that the tearful face is judged as sadder, more sincere, and more deserving of help. Tears, in other words, recruit kindness from those around us. They are a wordless message that says: I am not coping; please come closer.

**5**

Crying is not, however, evenly distributed. Women in most cultures cry more often than men — on average between two and four times as often, according to a 2011 survey by the German psychologist Ad Vingerhoets, who has spent much of his career on the subject. Some of this difference is hormonal: testosterone appears to suppress tear production, while the hormone prolactin, more abundant in adult women, appears to encourage it. Much of the difference, however, is cultural. Boys in many societies are taught from an early age that crying is shameful, while girls are not. Cross-cultural studies find that the gender gap in crying is widest in countries with the most rigid gender expectations, and almost vanishes in the most egalitarian.

**6**

Then there is the curious matter of crying at beauty. Most of us have, at some point, found ourselves with wet cheeks at a piece of music, a painting, or the closing minutes of a film, without being able to say quite **why**. Researchers call this phenomenon “aesthetic crying”, and several theories compete to explain it. One holds that great art produces a sudden flood of meaning that the brain cannot fully

process and that overflows, so to speak, into the tear ducts. Another holds that beauty taps into the same caregiving circuits as a distressed child or a lost friend, and we cry because we are, briefly, deeply moved by something we cannot help or hold. Neither theory is fully proven, but both point in the same direction: tears are not only about pain. They are also about being overwhelmed by something larger than ourselves.

**7**

What, finally, does crying **do** for the brain? Surveys repeatedly find that most people report feeling better after a cry — calmer, lighter, more emotionally stable — though laboratory studies have struggled to detect this effect with any reliability. One possibility is that the benefit comes not from the tears themselves but from what surrounds them: the comfort of a friend, the relief of finally putting feeling into the open, the slow regulation of breathing that follows a sob. If so, then crying may be less a chemical valve than a kind of summons — a way of bringing other people, and a calmer version of ourselves, towards us. In an age that prizes composure, that small wet message remains, biologically and socially, one of the most powerful things a human face can send.

**From Paragraph 1**

**12.** The writer says crying is “perhaps the most peculiar” of the things our bodies do. Give **two** reasons, from Paragraph 1, why the writer considers crying so peculiar. [2]

**From Paragraph 2**

**13.** According to Paragraph 2, what is the **difference in purpose** between basal tears and reflex tears? Answer in your own words. [2]

**14.** The writer says that the chemistry of emotional tears is “not the same” as that of other tears. What is the writer suggesting about emotional tears by drawing this distinction? [1]

**From Paragraph 3**

**15.** The writer says of the chemistry of emotional tears that it is “suggestive but not yet settled.” Explain, in your own words, what this means. [2]

**From Paragraph 4**

**16.** The writer says that human eyes are “unusually visible.” Why is this fact important to the writer’s argument about tears as a social signal? [2]

**17.** What is the effect of the writer’s phrase, “I am not coping; please come closer”? [2]

**From Paragraph 5**

**18.** According to Paragraph 5, give **two** reasons why women in most cultures cry more often than men. [2]

**19.** The writer says the gender gap in crying “almost vanishes in the most egalitarian” countries. What does this fact suggest about the cause of the gap? [2]

**From Paragraph 6**

**20.** The writer says that aesthetic crying happens when art produces “a sudden flood of meaning that the brain cannot fully process.” What is **effective** about the word **flood** in this sentence? [1]

**From Paragraph 7**

**21.** The writer ends the article by calling tears “that small wet message.” Explain what is **effective** about describing tears as a “message.” [2]

**22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]**

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **what scientists currently believe emotional tears may do**, and **why crying differs from person to person and culture to culture**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

**Scientists believe that emotional tears may ...**

— END OF PAPER —